

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, October 2, 2026

1,926 words · 8 min read

RE: Fiji passes Counter Narcotics Bureau law · Navy's two LHDs sidelined by propulsion failures · Ukraine drops Australian helicopter bid · EU envoy presses Canberra on AI rules · Pacific pre-COP31 guest list thin

ASX 200

8,682

+0.20%

AUD/USD

0.6943

-0.94%

NZX 50

13,680

-0.95%

NZD/USD

0.5615

-0.64%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's parliament created a Counter Narcotics Bureau with search, seizure and covert powers after fifty-two kilograms of cocaine vanished from Suva High Court evidence stores, one of eight bills passed in an overnight sitting.
- 2 The Royal Australian Navy's two largest warships, HMAS Canberra and HMAS Adelaide, are both sidelined by propulsion failures, The Australian reports, taking the fleet's primary amphibious lift out of service at the same time.
- 3 Pacific states press climate finance demands at a pre-COP31 meeting hosted by Fiji and Tuvalu even as Reuters reports the international guest list remains thin, with Anthony Albanese due to fly out on Monday.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji creates Counter Narcotics Bureau after cocaine scandal

Fiji's parliament passed legislation creating a Counter Narcotics Bureau with new powers to search, seize and run covert operations, one of eight bills passed in a sitting that began on October 1, 2026, and ended at 1:30 a.m. the next day. The law follows the disappearance of *fifty-two kilograms* of cocaine from Suva High Court evidence, including thirty-two kilograms swapped for flour. Political analyst **Jojo Tarai** said a freer media and "directed political will" have pushed the issue into the open.

per ABC Pacific: "New Counter Narcotics Bureau to lead Fiji's fight against drugs"

AU-DEFENSE

Navy's two largest warships sidelined by propulsion failures

HMAS Canberra and HMAS Adelaide, the Royal Australian Navy's largest warships, have both been sidelined by propulsion failures, The Australian reports. The simultaneous outage removes Australia's primary amphibious lift capacity from service at a time when the 2026 National Defence Strategy places weight on littoral manoeuvre and regional disaster response.

per The Australian: "Warship trouble at the double for Navy"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

EU envoy presses Australia to seize AI regulation opening

The EU's new envoy in Canberra said Europe and Australia can jointly demand greater regulation of artificial intelligence despite resistance from both China and the United States, **Matthew Knott** reports. The envoy warned Canberra not to let an "enormous opportunity" for closer EU-Australia cooperation slip, framing AI governance as the field where two middle-sized regulatory blocs can still set terms.

per Sydney Morning Herald (Matthew Knott): "EU envoy warns Australia not to let 'enormous opportunity' slip"

AU-DEFENSE

Ukraine withdraws request for Australian Army helicopters

Ukraine has withdrawn a request to acquire almost two dozen Australian Army helicopters, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. The withdrawal closes a transfer proposal that had been under consideration for aircraft already surplus to Australian Army requirements.

per Sydney Morning Herald: "Ukraine withdraws request to acquire Australian Army helicopters"

• OVERNIGHT

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Pacific pre-COP31 meeting opens with a thin guest list · Reuters

Reuters reports the Pacific Islands are getting their climate moment through the pre-COP31 meeting, but that the guest list of attending governments is thin. The gathering precedes the full COP31 summit in Turkey, which Australia is co-hosting with Pacific countries.

AU-POLITICS

Albanese flies to pre-COP on Monday with rate pain at home · ABC News

Anthony Albanese boards a plane on Monday bound for the pre-COP meeting in Fiji and Tuvalu, the ABC reports, with COP itself in Turkey weeks later and also on his itinerary. The ABC frames the Pacific leg as part of Australia's wider diplomacy in the contest over Chinese influence, while noting the Reserve Bank lifted rates this week to their highest level since 2011.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Super funds reject Farrell's plan to use savings in US tariff talks · The Australian

Superannuation funds have criticized Trade Minister **Don Farrell** over a plan to deploy Australian retirement savings as a bargaining chip with Washington, The Australian reports. A companion report says Farrell is eyeing super funds to shield Australian lamb exports from US tariffs.

AU-POLITICS

[Hanson and Spender jointly demand ATO reverse card payment ban](#) · Sydney Morning Herald

Pauline Hanson and **Allegra Spender** have called in a rare joint position for the Australian Taxation Office to reverse its plan to ban credit card payments for tax bills, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. The ATO announced the move in response to the Reserve Bank outlawing card surcharges, which the ABC reports cost Australians around \$1.6 billion a year.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Iranian threats against Australia-based diaspora escalate](#) · The Australian

The Australian reports escalating Iranian threats directed at members of the diaspora in Australia, quoting a warning that it would be "easy for us to reach him in Australia". The report adds to a running Australian debate over foreign interference directed at resident communities.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Colombia arrests alleged WA drug kingpin, extradition pending](#) · ABC News

Colombian police arrested Australian-Iranian national **Arash Ebrahimi Far**, wanted in Western Australia and in hiding in Colombia since December 2018, as he left hospital after being wounded by gunfire. He awaits potential extradition to Australia, where authorities allege he ran a large-scale network shipping drugs into Western Australia.

• STAT OF THE DAY

1 in 60

Fijian adults living with HIV

Fiji declared an HIV emergency last month and has now legalised needle exchange, joining Australia, New Zealand and PNG as the only Pacific states with a formal programme.

RNZ Pacific

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · CSIS

[CSIS publishes transcript of its AUKUS at five assessment](#)

CSIS has released the full transcript of its "AUKUS at Five: Progress, Challenges, and the Way Forward" session, following the event the brief carried on September 15, 2026. The transcript puts the panel's assessment of pillar progress and remaining obstacles on the record in full.

• PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

[Fiji legalises needle exchange to contain HIV emergency](#)

Fiji's parliament passed the HIV/AIDS (Amendment) Bill 2026, allowing distribution of sterile equipment, condoms, PrEP and counselling, which the Health Ministry called a "monumental milestone". Fiji declared an HIV emergency last month, with *one in 60 Fijian adults* now living with the virus, and joins Australia, New Zealand and Papua New Guinea as the only Pacific states running a formal needle and syringe programme.

TONGA · ABC NEWS

Tonga convicts Australian deportee in landmark gang case

A Tongan judge found **Eneasi Taumoeofolau**, deported from Australia, guilty of participating in an organised criminal group over his role establishing a Comancheros chapter, the first test of the Counter Terrorism and Transnational Crimes Act. He faces a maximum of 25 years and is already serving a life sentence for importing more than two kilograms of methamphetamine from the United States. New Zealand deportee **Tevita Shoji** was also convicted; two other Australian deportees were acquitted.

NIUE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Niue confirms two HIV cases linked to one household

Niue has confirmed two HIV cases within a single household, with Health Minister **K. Sinahemana Hekau** saying "the overall risk to the wider community remains low". Acting Director of Health **Minerva McCurdy Ikimau** said investigations found no evidence of wider transmission, and both patients are receiving treatment and counselling from the Department of Health.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC (WANTOK)

Masiu says he accepts losing PNG's ICT portfolio

Prime Minister **James Marape** replaced ICT Minister **Timothy Masiu** with **Robert Naguri**, Member for Bogia, in the July Cabinet reshuffle. Masiu, the Member for South Bougainville, told ABC's Wantok he was satisfied with his record in the portfolio and that Marape consulted him before the change.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG targets exit from financial grey list by 2028

The National Coordinating Committee on Anti-Money Laundering and Counter-Terrorist Financing says Papua New Guinea is expected to leave the global grey list by 2028 if it follows a three-year strategy, ABC Radio Australia reports. Journalist **Scott Waide** said the listing "does affect the ordinary Papua New Guinean", contrary to public perception.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

El Nino effects will diverge sharply across Pacific states

Pacific island countries may face different consequences from the same El Nino pattern, with warmer water, shifting sea levels and coral impacts varying by country, an ocean officer told Islands Business. The assessment lands as Pacific governments assemble climate finance demands for the pre-COP31 meeting.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Conservation International urges Fiji to drive pre-COP agenda

Hosting pre-COP31 in Fiji could put Pacific climate priorities at the centre of global negotiations and push world leaders toward action, Conservation International's **Mere Lakeba** told Islands Business. Fiji has said it will "hold the line" on 1.5 degrees at the meeting.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Urban drift leaves PNG elderly care on fewer shoulders

Papua New Guinea has no nursing homes, few formal aged care services and little government support, ABC Pacific reports, with migration to cities concentrating a customary duty on single family members. Dame **Carol Kidu** said the time for debate is over and the government must put measures in place, particularly in Port Moresby.

● NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon walks back minister's claim tying Greens to EU complaint

Christopher Luxon retreated from Trade Minister **Todd McClay**'s accusation that the Green Party was "joining with foreign actors to attack New Zealand" over a climate complaint lodged with the European Commission, then wrongly suggested the claim originated with reporters. Green co-leader **Chloe Swarbrick** said McClay had provided "zero evidence" for his "bizarre claim".

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

New Zealand atmospheric CO2 hits record 423.1 parts per million

Carbon dioxide measured at Baring Head in Wellington reached 423.1 parts per million in 2025, a *30 percent* rise since New Zealand monitoring began in 1972, Stats NZ data shows. Earth Sciences principal atmosphere technician **Gordon Brailsford** said each decade's growth rate exceeds the previous one.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Greens weigh an 'unashamedly populist' turn under Shoebridge

The Sydney Morning Herald examines whether Australia's new Greens leader can replicate the anti-establishment appeal of New York City's mayor and the UK's **Zack Polanski**. The paper describes the leader as a hard-left figure seeking to channel the same anger.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Shoebridge says Greens should have listened to Faruqi earlier

New Greens leader **David Shoebridge** said "I wish we'd listened to Faruqi before Bondi", The Australian reports, days after his election to the leadership and amid a dispute with **Mehreen Faruqi** over the ballot process.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Economists side with Minns against Chalmers on spending

Economists surveyed by The Australian do not back Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** on government spending, the paper reports, aligning instead with NSW Premier **Chris Minns**, who pressed Canberra for restraint after this week's inflation figures.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Canberra forecasts resource export income up 5 percent

Australia expects global commodity disruption to lift resource and energy export income by *5 percent*, Bloomberg reports. Brent crude sat at 99.47, down 5.52 percent, on October 2.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Firmus prices shares to raise \$5 billion

Australian data centre operator Firmus has priced shares to raise *\$5 billion*, according to a term sheet seen by Reuters. The raising lands as The Australian reports AirTrunk's Singapore data centre float facing a cool reception.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Proxy adviser urges ASX shareholders to reject pay report

A proxy adviser has called on shareholders of ASX Ltd to vote down the exchange operator's remuneration report, Reuters reports. The ASX 200 closed at 8,682, up 0.20 percent, on October 2.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · NEW ZEALAND GOVERNMENT

New Zealand government announces Wellington planning changes

The New Zealand government has released planning changes intended to support growth in Wellington, according to a Beehive release. The announcement comes five weeks out from the November 7 general election.

• UPCOMING

OCT
5

Albanese departs for pre-COP31 meeting in Fiji and Tuvalu

Australia's co-hosting of COP31 with Pacific states is being tested by a thin international guest list.

OCT
21

PNG NRL franchise due to launch its brand

IP Australia has not cleared the club's chosen name, leaving an Australian-funded PNG venture without secured trademark rights.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election

Early voting begins while climate and trade disputes dominate the campaign.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set Wellington's foreign and defence policy.

NOV
2026

COP31 in Turkey, co-hosted with Pacific states

Albanese's itinerary includes the summit, where Pacific members will press the climate finance demands raised at pre-COP.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Family Planning in PNG has a conversion problem

Kingtau Mambon of the University of Papua New Guinea finds a stark gap between wanted and actual fertility in PNG: women know about contraception but few can access it. The research was supported by the ANU-UPNG Partnership under the PNG-Australia Partnership, funded by the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

The Northern Territory must become an operational ecosystem

The Australian Army does not own most of the systems its future combat power depends on, the ASPI Strategist argues: ports, fuel, freight, telecommunications, electricity, cloud computing, satellites and skilled workforces sit largely outside the Department of Defence.

AU-POLITICS

ASPI STRATEGIST

AI could worsen radicalisation of young Australians

The piece builds on **Anthony Albanese's** UN General Assembly address calling for international cooperation on AI risk, arguing parliament needs evidence on how AI tools accelerate the radicalisation of young Australians.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ABC NEWS

Rudd on what the West gets wrong about China

Former prime minister and ambassador to the United States **Kevin Rudd**, now president and chief executive of the Asia Society, discusses Australia's strengths, the state of ties with Washington, and Western misreadings of China.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Japan and Australia: Toward a More Autonomous and Resilient Partnership

The piece argues the Japan-Australia relationship is shifting from parallel alliance management to direct mutual reliance. It frames that shift as a response to uncertainty about United States commitments.

Argument: Tokyo and Canberra are learning to depend on each other as confidence in Washington's reliability wavers.

THE DIPLOMAT

Australia as an AI Middle Power

The article catalogues Australian advantages in the AI transition and argues middle-power agency remains real. It lands the same day the EU envoy in Canberra pitched joint AI regulation.

Argument: Australia holds assets and resources that leave it far from powerless as AI reorders technological competition.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Disaster resilience is not the place for shifting fiscal burden

The piece argues those three jurisdictions already carry disproportionate disaster exposure. It warns budget repair should not come at the cost of resilience in Australia's north.

Argument: Shifting more disaster risk onto Queensland, the Northern Territory and Western Australia is the wrong way to repair the federal budget.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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